

In October 1945, French troops, aided by the British, reoccupied the Cambodian capital, Phnom Penh, and arrested the pro-independence prime minister, Son Ngoc Thanh. Meanwhile, in Laos, the anticolonial Lao Issara (Free Laos) movement, headed by Prince Phetsarath, carried out a coup against King Sisavang Vong. It was not until April 1946 that French forces recovered control of Laos, forcing Prince Phetsarath to take refuge in Thailand.

In both countries, France pursued a policy of political modernization, turning their traditional rulers into constitutional monarchs with governments answerable to elected assemblies. In 1949, France, struggling to recover the base they had in Indochina prior to the war, granted the two countries greater self-government but continued to control defense and security.

Thailand provided a safe base both for the Lao Issara and for the Cambodian pro-independence groups of the Khmer Issarak movement. Although not strong enough to seize power, these organizations established a threatening armed presence in areas of Cambodia and Laos. From 1950, they became linked to the Viet Minh guerrillas. The Lao Issara mutated into the pro-communist Pathet Lao, led by a member of the Lao royal family, Prince Souphanouvong. The Pathet Lao leader's half-brother, Prince Souvanna Phouma was also originally a member of Lao Issara, but in 1951 took the post of prime minister in the royal Lao government.



The three princes

Princes Boun Oum, Souvanna Phouma, and Souphanouvong celebrate an agreement at Geneva in 1962 that made Laos a neutral state under a coalition government. The smiles were shortlived, as the country's civil war and political chaos continued unabated.

The Viet Minh wades in

In 1953, the Viet Minh launched a major offensive in Laos in alliance with the Pathet Lao. It was partly in response to this that the French mounted their ill-fated operation at Dien Bien Phu in northwestern Vietnam. In the same year, King Sihanouk tried to salvage a worsening political situation in Cambodia. Menaced by Viet Minh-backed Issarak guerrillas